

MILO'S GRADED INDEPENDENCE ROADMAP

Extended Pen Independence Training Plan

Foundation sessions plus a carefully graded disappear-and-reappear ladder from 30 seconds to one hour

Core progression rule: two calmness scores of 4 or 5 on the same stage upgrade Milo one stage. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 move him down.

Important: Milo is still a very young miniature dachshund. The 30-minute-to-one-hour stages are future goals, not immediate targets.

Prepared July 2026

How This Extended Plan Works

This guide keeps the original calm-near-the-pen, distance and room-movement work, then adds a dedicated absence ladder. Harder means slightly more distance or time while Milo remains able to recover - not allowing more distress.

Important for Milo's age

At about six weeks old, Milo's bladder control, sleep regulation and ability to self-settle are still developing. Use the foundation plans now. Treat the longest absence stages as a roadmap for later development.

Automatic progression rule

Move up

Two completed attempts on the same challenge stage receive a calmness score of 4 or 5.

Move down

Two completed attempts on the same challenge stage receive a score of 1 or 2.

Repeat

A score of 3, or mixed scores, means repeat the current stage. For stages of 15 minutes or longer, the two calm attempts may occur on different days, with short easy sessions in between.

Calmness scale

Score	Meaning
1	Escalating, unable to settle or recover.
2	Frequently distressed; the stage is too difficult.
3	Mixed but manageable; repeat the stage.
4	Mostly calm and recovers well.
5	Calm, confident and comfortable.

Before Every Session

- Give Milo a toilet opportunity first.
- Choose a time when he is awake and reasonably calm - not overexcited, extremely hungry or overtired.
- Use part of his normal daily kibble allowance rather than unlimited extra treats.
- Place one safe familiar toy or chew in the pen.
- Keep departures and returns calm and ordinary.

What to Do When Milo Cries

What you see	What it probably means	What to do
Brief whine or one or two barks	Mild protest	Wait for a tiny pause, reward calmness and continue with an easier repetition.
Repeated barking but he still eats and pauses	Slightly too difficult	Reduce the planned absence by about half and add visible recovery time.
Continuous sharper crying, frantic scratching or refusing food	Too difficult	Return calmly, help him settle and end or move to a much easier stage.
Sudden crying after previously coping	Possible practical need	Check toileting, tiredness, temperature and physical comfort.

Rewarding after barking

Rewarding the first one-second pause is acceptable. You are reinforcing the quiet pause. Make the next repetition easier so you can reward before barking begins.

Do not turn it into a battle

Never shout, tap the pen, stare him down or deliberately leave him to escalate. The purpose is confidence, not proving that he can be ignored.

Daily Training and Long-Stage Rules

Three daily practice slots

The tracker allows up to three practices per day. During the early stages these can all be short sessions. Once the target reaches 15 minutes, do only one full challenge attempt that day and make the remaining practice slots short, easy consolidation work.

Long stages are not three times per day

Do not perform three 30-minute, 45-minute or one-hour attempts in one day. One full long attempt is enough. The other sessions should focus on calm pen entry, visible movement or an easy five-minute absence.

For targets of 15 minutes or longer

- Use an audio or video monitor when possible.
- Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress.
- Do not increase both the environmental difficulty and the timer together.
- Continue to account for age, toileting and sleep needs.
- Use the target as a ceiling, not an obligation to complete the timer.

Progress roadmap

Stage	Plan	Absence target	Approx. practice
Foundation 1 of 12	Safe and Calm Beside the Pen	No planned absence	10 min
Foundation 2 of 12	Small Distance Changes	No planned absence	10 min
Foundation 3 of 12	Moving Around the Room	No planned absence	10 min
Foundation 4 of 12	Extended Calm With You Nearby	No planned absence	15 min
Foundation 5 of 12	The Distance Ladder	No planned absence	15 min
Foundation 6 of 12	First Disappear-and-Reappear Practice	Target 3 sec	10 min
Foundation 7 of 12	Movement Plus First Absences	Target 3 sec	15 min
Foundation 8 of 12	Normal Household Activity	Target 5 sec	10 min
Foundation 9 of 12	Short Predictable Absences	Target 10 sec	15 min
Foundation 10 of 12	Mixed Short Absences	Target 10 sec	10 min
Foundation 11 of 12	Unpredictable Normal-Life Practice	Target 15 sec	15 min
Foundation 12 of 12	Bridge to 30 Seconds	Target 20 sec	15 min
Advanced 1 of 14	First Full 30 Seconds	Target 30 sec	10 min
Advanced 2 of 14	Steady 45-Second Absence	Target 45 sec	12 min
Advanced 3 of 14	One-Minute Independence	Target 1 min	15 min
Advanced 4 of 14	Ninety Seconds Out of Sight	Target 1 min 30 sec	15 min
Advanced 5 of 14	Two-Minute Calm	Target 2 min	18 min

Stage	Plan	Absence target	Approx. practice
Advanced 6 of 14	Three-Minute Routine	Target 3 min	20 min
Advanced 7 of 14	Five-Minute Independence	Target 5 min	25 min
Advanced 8 of 14	Eight-Minute Household Absence	Target 8 min	30 min
Advanced 9 of 14	Ten-Minute Calm Alone Time	Target 10 min	30 min
Advanced 10 of 14	Fifteen-Minute Independence	Target 15 min	35 min
Advanced 11 of 14	Twenty-Minute Independence	Target 20 min	40 min
Advanced 12 of 14	Thirty-Minute Independence	Target 30 min	50 min
Advanced 13 of 14	Forty-Five-Minute Independence	Target 45 min	65 min
Advanced 14 of 14	One-Hour Independence	Target 1 hr	75 min

Safe and Calm Beside the Pen

Difficulty: Very easy

Target: No planned absence

Best for: Milo still cries regularly, but can eat and settle when you stay close.

Goal: Teach him that the pen is safe even when you are present but not entertaining him.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Place Milo in the pen after a toilet break. Sit directly beside the pen, turned slightly sideways. Reward/adjustment: Drop 1 piece of kibble for any quiet pause, sniffing, sitting or looking away from you.
Minute 2	Remain beside the pen. Keep your hands to yourself and avoid eye contact. Reward/adjustment: Reward two or three calm moments. Do not reward every second.
Minute 3	Shift your chair or body about half a metre away. Reward/adjustment: If he stays quiet for 3-5 seconds, calmly place kibble into the pen.
Minute 4	Stay at the half-metre distance. Stand up once, then sit down again. Reward/adjustment: Reward after you sit if he remained calm or became quiet quickly.
Minute 5	Walk one step away and immediately return to your seat. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause after the movement. Make the next repetition smaller if barking increases.
Minute 6	Sit quietly and do something neutral, such as looking at a book or your phone. Reward/adjustment: Reward one or two settled behaviours, especially lying down or engaging with his toy.
Minute 7	Stand beside your chair for 5 seconds, then sit again. Reward/adjustment: Drop kibble only while he is quiet, even if the quiet pause lasts one second.
Minute 8	Take two slow steps away, pause briefly, then return to the chair. Reward/adjustment: Reward the first quiet moment after you return.
Minute 9	Return to sitting beside the pen and allow an easy minute. Reward/adjustment: Give one calm reward, then reduce food so he practises settling without constant feeding.
Minute 10	Finish with 20-30 seconds of calm beside the pen. Open the pen during a quiet pause. Reward/adjustment: Release him quietly. Avoid an excited greeting that makes leaving the pen the biggest reward.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Small Distance Changes

Difficulty: Easy

Target: No planned absence

Best for: Milo manages Level 1 with brief whining rather than escalating crying.

Goal: Help him cope while you move between beside the pen and a few steps away.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Start beside the pen for an easy success. Reward/adjustment: Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Move one metre away and sit down. Reward/adjustment: Reward after 5-10 seconds of calm. Return to deliver the kibble, then move away again.
Minute 3	Alternate between sitting beside the pen and one metre away. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm transitions, not only lying down.
Minute 4	Stand up, take three slow steps, and return. Reward/adjustment: Reward a pause in crying. If he remained quiet, wait a little longer before rewarding.
Minute 5	Sit one to two metres away for the full minute. Reward/adjustment: Give one or two pieces of kibble during calm behaviour.
Minute 6	Walk past the pen once without stopping, then sit down farther away. Reward/adjustment: Reward after you are seated if he is calm.
Minute 7	Move closer for an easier repetition, but do not interact through the bars. Reward/adjustment: Reward relaxed body language or quiet engagement with a toy.
Minute 8	Move two metres away, stand for 5-10 seconds, then return to your chair. Reward/adjustment: Reward only after a quiet pause.
Minute 9	Sit at the easier distance and ignore him politely. Reward/adjustment: Allow him to discover that calmness does not always produce immediate attention.
Minute 10	End beside the pen, then release during a quiet moment. Reward/adjustment: Use one final piece of kibble inside the pen before opening it.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Moving Around the Room

Difficulty: Easy-medium

Target: No planned absence

Best for: Milo can cope with you sitting one to two metres away.

Goal: Teach him that ordinary movement does not mean he must follow you.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Begin seated beside the pen for 30 seconds, then stand. Reward/adjustment: Reward one calm pause before moving.
Minute 2	Walk slowly around the room while remaining visible. Reward/adjustment: Approach and drop kibble after 10-15 seconds of calm.
Minute 3	Pick up or put down one harmless household item. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness after the small noise or movement.
Minute 4	Sit across the room for 20-30 seconds, then stand again. Reward/adjustment: Reward only once during this minute unless he is finding it difficult.
Minute 5	Walk past the pen twice without stopping. Reward/adjustment: After the second pass, reward a quiet pause.
Minute 6	Pause near a doorway but remain fully visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward if he watches without escalating.
Minute 7	Return nearer for an easier minute and sit quietly. Reward/adjustment: Reward relaxed behaviour, then allow a short food-free period.
Minute 8	Walk to the far side of the room, pause for 5 seconds, and return. Reward/adjustment: Reward the first quiet moment after you return.
Minute 9	Repeat a mixture of sitting, standing and walking. Reward/adjustment: Use unpredictable rewards so he is not waiting for food after every movement.
Minute 10	Finish with an easy seated position. Release calmly. Reward/adjustment: Open the pen after 1-2 seconds of quiet if possible.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Extended Calm With You Nearby

Difficulty: Very easy

Target: No planned absence

Best for: Milo can complete the easiest 10-minute sessions but is not ready for many disappearances.

Goal: Increase total session length without greatly increasing difficulty.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Settle Milo after toileting. Sit beside the pen. Reward/adjustment: Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Remain beside him without eye contact or conversation. Reward/adjustment: Reward quiet sitting, sniffing or lying down.
Minute 3	Move half a metre away. Reward/adjustment: Reward after 5 seconds of calm.
Minute 4	Sit quietly and reduce food delivery. Reward/adjustment: One calm reward at most.
Minute 5	Stand, take one step away, and sit again. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause.
Minute 6	Move one metre away for 20-30 seconds. Reward/adjustment: Return to deliver kibble, then move away again.
Minute 7	Come closer for an easy recovery minute. Reward/adjustment: Reward settled behaviour.
Minute 8	Stand beside the pen without interacting. Reward/adjustment: Reward if he remains calm while you are upright.
Minute 9	Walk two slow steps away and return. Reward/adjustment: Reward after calmness.
Minute 10	Sit one metre away and look occupied. Reward/adjustment: Allow a food-free stretch.
Minute 11	Walk once around the room while visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward when you return to your chair.
Minute 12	Remain close for a recovery minute. Reward/adjustment: One small reward for calmness.
Minute 13	Move one metre away again. Reward/adjustment: Reward after a slightly longer quiet period.
Minute 14	Sit beside the pen but continue ignoring politely. Reward/adjustment: Do not make the ending obvious or exciting.
Minute 15	Give one final calm reward and release during quietness. Reward/adjustment: End neutrally.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

The Distance Ladder

Difficulty: Easy

Target: No planned absence

Best for: Milo can stay calm with you nearby for 15 minutes.

Goal: Practise several distances while keeping you visible.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Start beside the pen. Reward/adjustment: Reward a calm start.
Minute 2	Move half a metre away. Reward/adjustment: Reward once.
Minute 3	Move one metre away. Reward/adjustment: Reward after 5-10 seconds of quiet.
Minute 4	Return closer for an easy minute. Reward/adjustment: Reward recovery.
Minute 5	Move two metres away and sit. Reward/adjustment: Reward once during calmness.
Minute 6	Stand at the same distance, then sit again. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm response to the change.
Minute 7	Walk across the room and return to the two-metre position. Reward/adjustment: Reward after you are seated.
Minute 8	Move beside the pen for recovery without interacting. Reward/adjustment: Minimal food.
Minute 9	Move to the far side of the room for 10-20 seconds. Reward/adjustment: Reward if manageable.
Minute 10	Walk past the pen without stopping. Reward/adjustment: Reward later, not immediately every time.
Minute 11	Sit two metres away and remain boring. Reward/adjustment: Allow a food-free settling period.
Minute 12	Move closer, then farther again. Reward/adjustment: Reward a calm transition.
Minute 13	Walk a small circle around the room. Reward/adjustment: Reward after a quiet pause.
Minute 14	Return to an easy distance. Reward/adjustment: One final calm reward.
Minute 15	Release quietly during a calm moment. Reward/adjustment: Avoid an excited greeting.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

First Disappear-and-Reappear Practice

Difficulty: Medium

Target: 3 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo stays manageable while you walk around the room.

Goal: Introduce extremely short moments when you are out of sight.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Start beside the pen and reward calmness. Reward/adjustment: Give one easy success before any disappearance.
Minute 2	Walk around the room while remaining visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward once after a calm stretch.
Minute 3	Step partly behind the doorway for 1 second, then reappear. Reward/adjustment: Return calmly and reward a quiet pause. Repeat only two or three times.
Minute 4	Remain visible and sit one to two metres away. Reward/adjustment: Use this as a recovery minute. Reward once if calm.
Minute 5	Disappear for 1-2 seconds, reappear, then continue walking normally. Reward/adjustment: Reward after quietness; do not rush directly to the pen every time.
Minute 6	Do three easy visible movements. Reward/adjustment: Reward the easiest calm repetition.
Minute 7	Disappear for 2-3 seconds once or twice. Reward/adjustment: If he barks, wait for a tiny pause when safe, return, reward, and reduce the next absence.
Minute 8	Sit nearby without interaction. Reward/adjustment: Allow him to settle without constant food.
Minute 9	Mix one 1-second disappearance with visible walking. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness unpredictably.
Minute 10	End with an easy visible minute and release calmly. Reward/adjustment: Finish before he becomes tired or frustrated.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Movement Plus First Absences

Difficulty: Easy-medium

Target: 3 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo manages visible distance changes and some 1-3 second disappearances.

Goal: Blend normal movement with very brief out-of-sight repetitions.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Start beside the pen. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness.
Minute 2	Walk slowly around the room. Reward/adjustment: Reward once.
Minute 3	Step out of sight for 1 second twice. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Sit one metre away for recovery. Reward/adjustment: One reward at most.
Minute 5	Complete a small visible household action. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness after the movement.
Minute 6	Disappear for 2 seconds once or twice. Reward/adjustment: Reduce difficulty if barking escalates.
Minute 7	Remain visible and sit across the room. Reward/adjustment: Allow a food-free stretch.
Minute 8	Walk past the doorway but do not disappear. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm response to the cue.
Minute 9	Disappear for 2-3 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Reward quietness after returning.
Minute 10	Come nearer for recovery without touching him. Reward/adjustment: Reward settled behaviour.
Minute 11	Walk around normally while visible. Reward/adjustment: One unpredictable reward.
Minute 12	Disappear for 1 second, then later for 3 seconds. Reward/adjustment: Keep both returns calm.
Minute 13	Sit one to two metres away. Reward/adjustment: Allow him to settle.
Minute 14	Finish with visible, easy movement. Reward/adjustment: Reward one calm moment.
Minute 15	Release quietly. Reward/adjustment: End before overtired crying begins.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Normal Household Activity

Difficulty: Medium-hard

Target: 5 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo handles 1-3 second disappearances with only mild protest.

Goal: Make pen time feel like part of ordinary life rather than a formal exercise.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Settle him with a safe toy while you sit nearby. Reward/adjustment: Reward one calm start.
Minute 2	Walk around and complete a tiny household task. Reward/adjustment: Reward after 15-20 seconds of calm.
Minute 3	Disappear for 2-4 seconds, then return without making eye contact. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause after you are back.
Minute 4	Sit across the room and ignore him politely. Reward/adjustment: One calm reward at most.
Minute 5	Walk past the pen, touch the door handle, and remain visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness around the departure cue.
Minute 6	Disappear for 3-5 seconds once or twice. Reward/adjustment: Reduce to 1-2 seconds if the crying becomes sharper or more continuous.
Minute 7	Return to visible movement and an easier distance. Reward/adjustment: Reward recovery and calm engagement with the toy.
Minute 8	Carry out another small normal task while visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward after a longer quiet stretch.
Minute 9	Mix one short disappearance with two easy visible movements. Reward/adjustment: Reward only one of the three repetitions.
Minute 10	Sit calmly near the pen, then release during quietness. Reward/adjustment: End neutrally, without a big reunion.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Short Predictable Absences

Difficulty: Medium

Target: 10 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo can recover quickly after 2-3 second disappearances.

Goal: Build absences of approximately 3-10 seconds while mixing in many easy repetitions.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Start close and easy. Reward/adjustment: Reward one calm pause.
Minute 2	Move around while visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward once.
Minute 3	Disappear for 3 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Sit nearby for recovery. Reward/adjustment: Minimal food.
Minute 5	Disappear for 4-5 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: If he copes, reward calmly.
Minute 6	Complete two visible movements. Reward/adjustment: Reward one of them.
Minute 7	Disappear for 3 seconds, return, and remain visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward after calmness.
Minute 8	Sit farther away for a quiet minute. Reward/adjustment: Allow independent settling.
Minute 9	Disappear for 5-7 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Halve the next absence if crying becomes continuous.
Minute 10	Come closer for recovery. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness, not excitement.
Minute 11	Walk past the pen and touch the door handle. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm response to the cue.
Minute 12	Disappear for 3 seconds, then later for 6-8 seconds. Reward/adjustment: Keep the second repetition optional if he is tired.
Minute 13	Remain visible and boring. Reward/adjustment: No reward unless needed.
Minute 14	Finish with an easy visible minute. Reward/adjustment: One final calm reward.
Minute 15	Release during a quiet pause. Reward/adjustment: End neutrally.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Mixed Short Absences

Difficulty: Hard

Target: 10 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo usually settles quickly after 3-5 second absences.

Goal: Build flexibility with different distances and brief absences without making every repetition harder.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Start close and easy. Reward/adjustment: Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Move around the room while visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward once.
Minute 3	Disappear for 3 seconds, then remain visible for the rest of the minute. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness after returning.
Minute 4	Sit one metre away for an easy recovery minute. Reward/adjustment: Minimal food; encourage independent settling.
Minute 5	Disappear for 5-8 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: If calm, reward after returning. If he cries continuously, halve the next absence.
Minute 6	Complete two easy visible movements. Reward/adjustment: Reward one calm repetition.
Minute 7	Disappear for 3 seconds, return, then later disappear for 6-10 seconds. Reward/adjustment: Keep your return calm and ordinary.
Minute 8	Stay visible but farther away. Reward/adjustment: Reward a settled posture or quiet play.
Minute 9	Mix one easy 1-second absence and one harder 5-10 second absence. Reward/adjustment: Reward only after quietness; do not increase both distance and duration at once.
Minute 10	Finish close to the pen and release calmly. Reward/adjustment: End while he is still coping, not after a final difficult test.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Unpredictable Normal-Life Practice

Difficulty: Medium-hard

Target: 15 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo manages 5-10 second absences without escalating.

Goal: Prevent him from predicting exactly when you leave, return or reward.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Start beside the pen and then move away. Reward/adjustment: Reward one calm start.
Minute 2	Perform a normal visible task. Reward/adjustment: Reward after a longer calm stretch.
Minute 3	Disappear for 5 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Return calmly; reward quietness.
Minute 4	Sit across the room. Reward/adjustment: No reward unless he settles particularly well.
Minute 5	Walk past the pen twice without stopping. Reward/adjustment: Reward later, not immediately.
Minute 6	Disappear for 8-12 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Reduce to 3-5 seconds if needed.
Minute 7	Return and continue the task rather than going directly to him. Reward/adjustment: Reward after he is quiet.
Minute 8	Sit nearby for recovery. Reward/adjustment: One small reward.
Minute 9	Disappear for 3 seconds, then remain visible. Reward/adjustment: Easy repetition.
Minute 10	Complete a quiet household task for the full minute. Reward/adjustment: Reward at the end if calm.
Minute 11	Disappear for 10-15 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Only attempt if the previous minutes were manageable.
Minute 12	Return and sit one to two metres away. Reward/adjustment: Allow him to settle without immediate food.
Minute 13	Mix visible walking with one 5-second absence. Reward/adjustment: Reward unpredictably.
Minute 14	Finish close and calm. Reward/adjustment: One final reward inside the pen.
Minute 15	Release quietly during calmness. Reward/adjustment: No big reunion.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Bridge to 30 Seconds

Difficulty: Hard

Target: 20 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo usually recovers quickly after 10-15 second disappearances.

Goal: Practise flexible 10-20 second absences before beginning the dedicated 30-second ladder.

Time	What to do
Minute 1	Begin close and easy. Reward/adjustment: Reward calmness.
Minute 2	Walk around while visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward once.
Minute 3	Disappear for 8-10 seconds. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Sit nearby for recovery. Reward/adjustment: Minimal food.
Minute 5	Disappear for 15-20 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Return earlier if distress escalates.
Minute 6	Stay visible and perform an easy task. Reward/adjustment: Reward recovery.
Minute 7	Disappear for 5 seconds only. Reward/adjustment: This easier repetition prevents constant escalation.
Minute 8	Sit across the room for the full minute. Reward/adjustment: Allow independent settling.
Minute 9	Disappear for approximately 15-20 seconds once. Reward/adjustment: Attempt this only while he remains manageable; return earlier if crying escalates.
Minute 10	Return and remain visible. Reward/adjustment: Reward after quietness.
Minute 11	Complete two easy visible movements. Reward/adjustment: Reward one calm response.
Minute 12	Repeat an easier 8-12 second disappearance rather than adding a longer final test. Reward/adjustment: End with confidence. The next stage contains the first dedicated 30-second attempt.
Minute 13	Return and sit near the pen for recovery. Reward/adjustment: Give one calm reward.
Minute 14	Keep the final minute easy and visible. Reward/adjustment: Do not add a last difficult test.
Minute 15	Release quietly during calmness. Reward/adjustment: End while he is coping.

Success check

Repeat this level if Milo is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

First Full 30 Seconds

Difficulty: Advanced - introductory

Target: 30 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the 10-20 second bridge stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 30 sec without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (5 sec)	Disappear completely for about 5 sec, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (15 sec)	Disappear for approximately 15 sec, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (30 sec)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 30 sec. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Steady 45-Second Absence

Difficulty: Advanced - introductory

Target: 45 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 45 sec without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (10 sec)	Disappear completely for about 10 sec, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (20 sec)	Disappear for approximately 20 sec, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (45 sec)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 45 sec. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

One-Minute Independence

Difficulty: Advanced - introductory

Target: 1 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 min without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (15 sec)	Disappear completely for about 15 sec, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (30 sec)	Disappear for approximately 30 sec, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (1 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 1 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Ninety Seconds Out of Sight

Difficulty: Advanced - developing

Target: 1 min 30 sec completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 min 30 sec without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (20 sec)	Disappear completely for about 20 sec, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (45 sec)	Disappear for approximately 45 sec, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (1 min 30 sec)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 1 min 30 sec. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Two-Minute Calm

Difficulty: Advanced - developing

Target: 2 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 2 min without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (30 sec)	Disappear completely for about 30 sec, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (1 min)	Disappear for approximately 1 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (2 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 2 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Three-Minute Routine

Difficulty: Advanced - developing

Target: 3 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 3 min without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (45 sec)	Disappear completely for about 45 sec, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (1 min 30 sec)	Disappear for approximately 1 min 30 sec, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (3 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 3 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Five-Minute Independence

Difficulty: Advanced - moderate

Target: 5 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 5 min without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (1 min)	Disappear completely for about 1 min, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (2 min)	Disappear for approximately 2 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (5 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 5 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Eight-Minute Household Absence

Difficulty: Advanced - moderate

Target: 8 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 8 min without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (1 min 30 sec)	Disappear completely for about 1 min 30 sec, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (3 min)	Disappear for approximately 3 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (8 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 8 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Ten-Minute Calm Alone Time

Difficulty: Advanced - moderate

Target: 10 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 10 min without escalating distress.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (2 min)	Disappear completely for about 2 min, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (10 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 10 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Fifteen-Minute Independence

Difficulty: Advanced - substantial

Target: 15 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 15 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (15 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 15 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Twenty-Minute Independence

Difficulty: Advanced - substantial

Target: 20 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 20 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (20 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 20 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Thirty-Minute Independence

Difficulty: Advanced - long

Target: 30 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 30 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (30 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 30 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Forty-Five-Minute Independence

Difficulty: Advanced - long

Target: 45 min completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 45 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (45 min)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 45 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

One-Hour Independence

Difficulty: Advanced - future goal

Target: 1 hr completely out of sight

Best for: Milo has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 hr without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Time	What to do
Preparation	Give Milo a toilet opportunity, check that he is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen. Reward/adjustment: Begin only when he can take food and his body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments. Reward/adjustment: Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test him.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly. Reward/adjustment: Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while Milo settles again. Reward/adjustment: If he does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner. Reward/adjustment: Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if Milo can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal. Reward/adjustment: It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (1 hr)	Leave Milo out of sight for the stage target of 1 hr. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available. Reward/adjustment: Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let Milo settle before ending the practice. Reward/adjustment: Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Success check

Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Final Reminders

Confidence first

The aim is not silence at all costs. The aim is that Milo can stay manageable, recover and gradually learn that departures are temporary.

Two calm results upgrade

Record each attempt honestly. Two 4-or-5 results on the same stage move up. Score 3 repeats. Two 1-or-2 results move down.

Future goals

Thirty minutes, 45 minutes and one hour belong at the far end of the ladder. Reaching them may take weeks or months and should follow Milo's age, toileting ability and emotional readiness.

Use the website tracker to store results, view the next recommended plan and open every session instruction.